TAKING ART TO NEW HEIGHTS

EXHIBITION

The extensive art collection of **Air India** gets a comprehensive showcase at NGMA Bengaluru



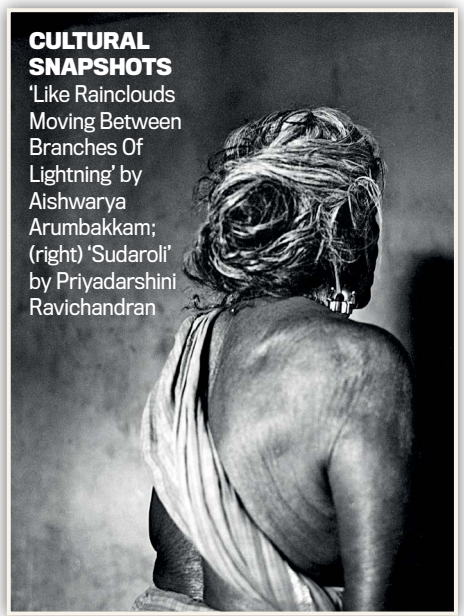


At the crossroads of aviation history and artistic heritage stands *Sanhitha–New Beginning for the Air India Collection*, an ambitious exhibition on for the next few months at the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA), Bengaluru. Curated by Subarna Patro and Darshan Kumar YU, this show is far more than a retrospective—it is a cultural reckoning, a reimagining of six decades of modern Indian art through the unique prism of one of India's most iconic institutions: Air India.

Founded in 1947 by J.R.D. Tata, Air India has long symbolised progress and cosmopolitan flair. Less widely known, however, is the airline's pivotal role as a patron of modern Indian art. In a post-Independence landscape with limited institutional support, Air India pioneered a visionary model—placing art in booking offices, lounges and aircraft. Through thoughtful acquisitions and bold commissions, the airline helped forge a vibrant visual identity for a newly sovereign nation—now preserved within the NGMA's historic walls.

What began with a few portraits of rural women, exchanged for air tickets, evolved into one of India's most eclectic corporate collections. M.F. Husain famously bartered paintings for global travel on Air India flights—a testament to the airline's belief in artistic exchange over commercial value.

"Curating the Air India Collection involves balancing modern and tradi-



CULTURAL SNAPSHOTS
'Like Rainclouds Moving Between Branches Of Lightning' by Aishwarya Arumbakkam; (right) 'Sudaroli' by Priyadarshini Ravichandran



PHOTOGRAPHY

Documenting the **Tamil Experience**

Vaanyerum Vizhuthugal, an evocative exhibition, reimagines the possibilities of photographic storytelling

From April 19 to July 20, the Museum of Art & Photography (MAP), Bengaluru, presents *Vaanyerum Vizhuthugal: Roots That Reach for the Sky*—its first group exhibition dedicated to contemporary photography and lens-based practices. Curated by self-taught artist Jaisingh Nageswaran, this evocative show features 12 Tamil-origin artists whose works reimagine the possibilities of photographic storytelling.

First shown as part of the Chennai Photo Biennale 2024–2025, *Vaanyerum Vizhuthugal* poetically translates from Tamil as 'Roots That Reach for the Sky'. "Usually, roots grow downward into the soil," says Nageswaran. "But in this case, metaphorically, the roots reach toward the sky. That inversion inspired me—it comes from